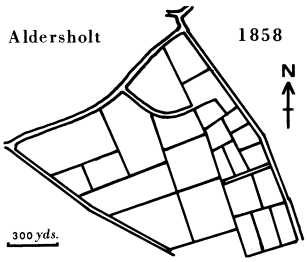
Alderholt — A Village Overview

Alderholt is a village and parish in East Dorset. It was once part of the larger Cranborne Parish, but it became an ecclesiastical parish on 6th November 1849 and has now an area of 3,769 acres.

It does not boast many places of interest because for many years it was a sparsely inhabited area of heathland. Only in recent years has the village grown to what it is today. Between 1851 and 1975 the population rose by 160 to 800. But today it is over 3000!

By tradition, the Battle of Catgurnion was fought between King Arthur and the Saxons before he marched to retake Witesbury (Whitsbury).

The village was not always where it is today. The main settlement was along Alderholt Street (now called Sandleheath Road). Like any typical village we find the church (St. Clements), farms, the mill, a blacksmith, a Manor, a village green and pond and the public house (the New Inn).



In 1858 part of Alderholt Heath to the south was enclosed by act of parliament. This action provoked much opposition among the cottagers (commoners) as they took it to be an invasion of their common rights.

With the building of a new road along the northern edge (Station Road / Park Bottom), the freeholders (among whom Mr. Churchill and Lord Salisbury were the largest landowners) began to build many cottages. As more land was enclosed from the waste, more cottages were built. Alderholt Street ceased to be the main area of population and the settlement along the Fordingbridge – Cranborne road became the new centre of the village. Since 1975 nearly half the enclosed land has been built on.

Churches

St. Clements

Built in medieval times and situated on Alderholt Street. Dedicated to St. Clement, Bishop and Martyr and was a 'chapel of ease' for the Cranborne Church. It is referred to in a document of 1574. The church was destroyed by Cromwell's army in the civil war and fell into ruin.

Ebenezer

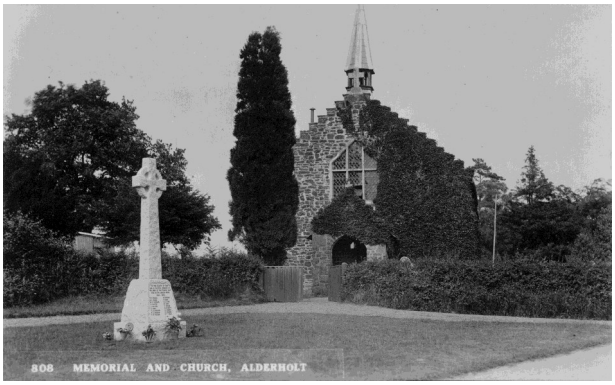
The Congregationalists built a chapel of mud and thatch at Cripplestyle in 1807. This collapsed in 1976. The site is marked by a memorial stone and garden.

Alderholt Chapel

A mud and slate building was built in 1820. A brick replacement was built in 1861. This was pulled down in the late fifties. The existing building was opened in 1923 and redeveloped in 2011.

St. James

Built from locally quarried sandstone and consecrated in 1849. It is situated in the geographical centre of the parish and dedicated to St. James the greater, Apostle and Martyr. Extended in 1922.



Crendell Methodist

The present building is dated 1870. It was closed in 2011.

Williams Memorial

Built in 1888 to replace Ebenezer. Named in memory of Samuel Williams, for forty years a pastor. The congregation joined with Alderholt in 2000. The building is now an art studio.

Tabernacle Full Gospel Church

In Camel Green. Opened in June 1938. It was closed in 2020.

Industries

Pottery

The parish straddles a narrow band of clay situated between the chalk uplands of Cranborne Chase and the sandy heathland to the south and east. From records it is known that a community of potters had become established on the edge of this heathland at Alderholt by the early 14th century. The last kilns operated in the area towards the end of the 19th century. A kiln mound can still be seen at the Salisbury Arms farm on Presseys corner.

Bricks

The same clay was used to make bricks for local use. Billets and Rakes were situated in Camel Green, Pagets in the station yard (where the surplus stores used to be). There were other Brickworks near Alderholt Mill and on Hillbury Road. A lot of the bricks were used in Bournemouth. Production stopped just before the last war.

Hurdles and Thatching Spars

Made from Hazel, cut from coppices. Several people were involved in this trade. Wilfred Foster (pictured) at Cripplestyle. Peter Bond was the last hurdler in the area. The product is now no longer financially viable due to modern production techniques.

Public Houses

The Churchill Arms	Originally called the Railway Arms. Situated near the Daggons Road station.
The Gold Oak Bar	Halfway between Alderholt and Cranborne. Now a private house. Until a few years ago the writing of the bar was still visible on the farmhouse wall.
The New Inn	Alderholt Street. Converted to two cottages before 1850.
The Red Lion	Fordingbridge Road. Now Red Lion Cottage.
The Salisbury Arms	The ruins of this public house on Pressey's corner stand in the grounds of Salisbury Arms Farm.

There were also several micro-breweries in the area.

The Churchill Arms is the only one that has remained open.

Schools

There were "Little Dame" schools at Alderholt Street, Crendell and Cripplestyle. The National School, St. James was built in 1847.

This school was enlarged several times until 1982 when a new building was built on Park Lane.

Amenities

Village Hall

Built in the early 1920's. A new hall built by a local builder was opened in 1968.

Reading Room

Built in 1904 through the generosity of Lord and Lady Salisbury. It was intended for silent reading as there was no village hall at the time.

Railways

The Salisbury and Dorset Line was opened in 1866. Lord Beeching closed the line in 1963. The bridge has been demolished and Daggons Road station is now private housing.

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